



Marketing as a Modern Coup d'État: Developing a Strategic Framework for Analysing Electoral Influence on TikTok

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Abstract

This dissertation examines how electoral influence may be constructed through TikTok using Călin Georgescu's 2024 Romanian presidential campaign as a case study. The research focuses on the relationship between political marketing, influencer communication and platform-native content, with particular attention to forms of political promotion that may not resemble conventional advertising or direct candidate endorsement. A qualitative Template Analysis was conducted on a sample of 20 TikTok videos associated with the wider influencer campaign surrounding the election. The analysis identified four overarching themes: Constructing the Ideal President; Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement; Dissatisfaction and Desire for Change; and Audience Engagement and Voting Mobilisation. Across the sample, creators repeatedly described presidential suitability through qualities such as honesty, competence, patriotism and demonstrated action, generally without naming a preferred candidate. This created a communication structure in which audiences were presented with criteria through which candidates could subsequently be evaluated. The findings were synthesised into a strategic framework proposing that electoral influence on TikTok may develop through organised campaign coordination, creator adaptation, construction of political criteria, indirect candidate framing and audience mobilisation. The framework also proposes a possible transition from coordinated astroturfing towards more organic or grassroots amplification when political messages resonate with existing audience values or dissatisfaction. The study does not claim to demonstrate direct effects on voting behaviour, but instead identifies a potential communication process through which political meanings and candidate evaluations may be shaped on TikTok. Limitations relating to sample size, deleted content, platform data access and the depth of Template Analysis are acknowledged, with future research recommended using multimodal, network and audience-based methods.

1. Introduction

Social media has become an increasingly important environment for political communication, changing not only how candidates communicate with voters but also how political messages are produced, circulated and encountered. TikTok is particularly significant within this development because political content exists alongside entertainment, lifestyle videos, humour and creator-led communication. As a result, users may encounter electoral messages without actively seeking political information or recognising the content as part of a wider communication strategy. Research has highlighted how TikTok can blur the distinction between entertainment and political discourse, while its recommendation systems allow content from both established and relatively unknown creators to gain rapid visibility (WFD & LSMO, 2026).

These characteristics create new challenges for understanding electoral influence. Traditional political advertising is usually identifiable through campaign branding, party affiliation or formal sponsorship, whereas political communication on TikTok can appear through personal opinions, creator recommendations, trends, hashtags and apparently organic discussion. TikTok prohibits paid political advertising and compensated political creator content, yet political narratives can still circulate through forms of communication that do not resemble conventional advertising. This raises questions about how marketing principles such as positioning, repetition, influencer communication, authenticity and audience engagement may operate within electoral contexts where the commercial or political origin of a message is less immediately visible. The distinction is also important from a regulatory perspective, since European platform governance increasingly addresses not only individual pieces of content but also recommender systems, coordinated activity, transparency and wider systemic risks to electoral integrity.

The 2024 Romanian presidential election provides a significant case through which to examine these issues. Independent candidate Călin Georgescu attracted limited attention in conventional polling before the first round but subsequently finished first with 22.94 per cent of valid votes. His campaign became strongly associated with TikTok visibility and attracted scrutiny over the role of coordinated promotion, influencer activity and platform recommendation systems. Following the election, concerns surrounding TikTok became a wider European governance issue, with the European Commission examining whether the platform had adequately assessed and mitigated risks relating to election integrity, recommender systems and coordinated manipulation (European Commission, 2024). The case therefore offers an opportunity to examine electoral communication not simply as

candidate advertising, but as a wider digital strategy involving creators, platform-native content and repeated political narratives.

This dissertation focuses particularly on a documented influencer campaign in which creators were encouraged to discuss the qualities that Romania's future president should possess. A Snoop investigation reported that 130 influencers were recruited through the FameUp platform to produce short videos based around presidential qualities, while the guidance encouraged creators to communicate in the style already familiar to their audiences (Neag et al., 2024). The analysed content is therefore useful for exploring how a shared strategic direction can be translated into apparently individual creator communication, and how political positioning may occur without an explicit instruction to support a named candidate.

The aim of this research is to develop a strategic framework for analysing how marketing and platform-native communication techniques may contribute to electoral influence on TikTok, using Călin Georgescu's 2024 Romanian presidential campaign as the central case study. The study does not attempt to establish that exposure to TikTok directly caused particular voting decisions. Instead, it examines the communication strategies and conditions through which political meanings, candidate qualities and calls for participation were constructed and circulated. This distinction reflects the wider principle that audience effects cannot be inferred solely from message content, since viewers may accept, reject or reinterpret political communication according to their existing beliefs and experiences.

The research has four objectives:

- To examine how political marketing, public relations, propaganda and platform governance provide on TikTok.
- To analyse a focused sample of 20 TikTok videos associated with the campaign using Template Analysis, supported by contextual platform data.
- To identify recurring patterns in the construction of presidential suitability, indirect candidate framing, dissatisfaction and change, and audience engagement and mobilisation.
- To synthesise the findings into a strategic framework for analysing how electoral influence may operate through TikTok's creator-led and platform-native communication.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Marketing, Public Relations and Propaganda

TO understand how electoral influence operates through contemporary media, it is first necessary to examine the origins of organised persuasion and clarify how propaganda is understood within this study. Because propaganda has been defined differently across historical, political and academic contexts, this research adopts a specific working definition. For the purposes of this research, propaganda is understood as strategically organised political communication intended to shape perceptions, attitudes or behaviour in favour of a particular actor, cause or worldview. It may involve selective presentation, repetition, emotional framing, symbolic appeals and the concealment or ambiguity of sponsorship or coordination. What distinguishes propaganda from ordinary democratic persuasion is not the presence of persuasion itself, but the extent to which communication weakens informed evaluation by obscuring its origins, marginalising competing interpretations, distorting evidence or creating a misleading impression of public support. Propaganda is therefore treated here as a matter of communicative purpose and practice, rather than as a label automatically applied to all persuasive political content.

Although propaganda is frequently associated with twentieth-century warfare and authoritarian politics, the term has much earlier institutional roots. Welch (2014) traces it to the Catholic Church's *Sacra Congregatio de Propaganda Fide* (Figure 1), made permanent in 1622 to manage missionary activity and propagate the faith. Its meaning and scale later changed as mass literacy, widening political participation and new communication technologies allowed states and other institutions to address increasingly large audiences. Propaganda became particularly important during the twentieth century, when governments sought to organise public opinion both during conflict and in peacetime. Bernays (1928) extended this principle beyond state propaganda by presenting public opinion as something that communication specialists could study and strategically shape. Drawing on group psychology, he argued that persuasive ideas could be connected to existing emotions, social identities and trusted authorities, rather than communicated only through factual argument. This approach helped connect propaganda with the emerging practice of public relations, but it also placed considerable power in the hands of those controlling messages and their distribution. Fallon (2022) therefore questions Bernays' assumption that organised persuasion could benefit democracy, noting that he did not adequately explain which ethical principles should govern it or whose interests it ultimately served.



Figure 1: Collegio de Propaganda Fide in Rome by Giovanni Battista Falda, 1665. Engraving depicting the institution associated with the Catholic Church's organised propagation of the faith and the historical development of the term propaganda (Wikimedia Commons, n.d.).

The development of marketing and public relations introduced more formal and relationship-based approaches to strategic communication, although neither practice can be separated completely from persuasion. The meaning and scope of marketing have evolved considerably over time. Wilkie and Moore (2003) identify four broad eras of marketing thought: the founding of the field between 1900 and 1920, when attention centred largely on distribution; its formalisation between 1920 and 1950 through the development of accepted principles and professional institutions; a shift towards managerial, behavioural and quantitative perspectives between 1950 and 1980; and increasing fragmentation and specialisation from 1980 onwards. The American Marketing Association currently defines marketing as “the activity, set of institutions, and processes for creating, communicating, delivering, and exchanging offerings that have value for customers, clients, partners, and society at large” (American Marketing Association, 2024). Marketing therefore extends beyond advertising and promotion, encompassing the creation, communication, delivery and exchange of offerings. In practice, these processes may involve audience research, segmentation, targeting, positioning and the communication of an offering's value. An offering does not need to be a physical product; it may also take the form of a service, organisation, idea or cause. Marketing can consequently be understood as a goal-directed and persuasive practice that seeks to influence how an offering is perceived and encourage audiences to engage with it.

Public relations addresses a wider range of relationships than those between a business and its customers, including relationships with employees, journalists, investors, government bodies, local communities and other groups affected by the organisation's activities. In an

electoral context, these publics may also include voters, party members, campaign volunteers, electoral authorities, civil-society groups and online communities. Grunig and Hunt (1984) describe public relations as “the management of communication between an organisation and its publics” (p. 6). This definition positions public relations as a managerial function rather than simply a communication technique, emphasising the ongoing coordination of communication with the different groups connected to an organisation. As a managerial function, public relations may include investigative and informative activities, but its broader purpose is to influence how an organisation is understood and how it relates to its publics. Marketing is inherently persuasive and goal-directed, seeking to influence how an offering is perceived and encourage audiences to engage with it. Santilli (1983) distinguishes between the informative and persuasive functions of advertising, arguing that information can support reasoned decision-making, while persuasion attempts to encourage a particular response. For Santilli, persuasion becomes ethically problematic when emotional or irrational appeals weaken the audience’s ability to evaluate information independently. Gregory (2010) similarly recognises that communication may attempt to influence awareness, attitudes and behaviour, but rejects the assumption that these stages follow automatically. Audiences interpret messages through their existing beliefs, experiences and cultural environments, meaning that they may accept, reject or reinterpret the intended message. This implies that the meaning and persuasive effect of communication cannot be determined solely from the communicator’s intentions or the content of the message. The same political message may reinforce existing beliefs for some audiences, be resisted by others or acquire an unintended meaning in different social and cultural contexts.

These distinctions become less stable when strategic communication is applied to politics. Rhetoric concerns the purposeful choices communicators make in language and style, and how those choices serve their communicative aims (Hansen, 2014). These choices may involve word selection, sentence structure and other stylistic devices used to shape how a message is presented and understood. Political actors may combine rhetorical devices with targeting, emotional association, repetition and carefully managed imagery to present candidates or ideas as credible, desirable or socially relevant. Such techniques are not inherently propagandistic, since persuasion is a normal component of democratic campaigning. The boundary becomes less clear when communication is designed to control perception by selecting favourable information, marginalising criticism or concealing the interests behind a message. This practice is commonly described as spin doctoring. Valentini (2015) explains that the term is used critically to describe political image management associated with selective framing, exaggeration and, in some cases, deception. Spin doctoring therefore contrasts with the transparent and dialogic understanding of public relations,

although the distinction is not always clear in practice. Marketing, public relations and propaganda cannot be differentiated solely by the techniques they employ. Their differences also depend on purpose, transparency, evidence and the degree to which audiences are allowed to evaluate competing interpretations. When persuasion disguises its origins or restricts informed judgement in order to advance a particular interest, it moves closer to propaganda. This conceptual foundation is necessary for examining how political images, identities and claims to authenticity are constructed within electoral communication.

2.2 Political Marketing and the Construction of Electoral Appeal

Political marketing literature commonly treats candidate image as a strategic attempt to establish a recognisable position among voters. Baines et al. (2014) define positioning as “how an offering is communicated and represented in a target audience’s mind” (p. 173), while distinguishing between the meaning intended by a campaign and the perceptions audiences actually form. This distinction is important because political image cannot be assumed to pass unchanged from communicator to voter. It should also not be reduced to party affiliation, since a political actor may be recognised through personal characteristics, ideological commitments, communication style and a deliberate relationship with, or distance from, established organisations. Social media has expanded the range of interactions through which these perceptions can develop. Hultman et al. (2019) examine candidate image through perceptions of trustworthiness, attractiveness, candidness, morality, originality and competence. Their study of younger UK voters found that social media content, interaction, credibility and online word of mouth contributed positively to perceived candidate image. However, the connection with voter-candidate relationships was often “an indirect one, mediated through the political candidate’s image” (Hultman et al., 2019, p. 1). Candidate positioning can therefore be understood as an attempt to organise personal, political and communicative characteristics into a coherent public identity, rather than simply promoting a party label.

Beyond establishing a recognisable candidate image, political appeal may also be constructed by connecting messages with collective identities and symbolic narratives. Huddy (2001) argues that political identity cannot be explained simply through membership of a national, religious or ideological group, because its consequences depend on the identity’s subjective meaning and strength. As she observes, “American identity does not mean the same thing to all Americans” (p. 130), demonstrating that apparently shared identities may contain contested understandings of belonging, values and legitimate membership. Campaign narratives can organise these meanings through simplified contrasts such as ordinary citizens against elites, national decline against renewal, or social threat against protection. In doing so, they may

define who belongs to the political community, which values represent it and which actors are presented as responsible for its problems. In summary, electoral appeal involves more than presenting policies or promoting a party label. Candidates attempt to create recognisable meanings through positioning, personal characteristics, collective identity and narrative framing, but audiences do not necessarily interpret these messages as intended. Their responses remain shaped by existing beliefs, experiences and social identities. Digital communication adds further opportunities for interaction and strategic image management, while also making credibility and audience interpretation increasingly important.

2.3 Platform Governance, Regulation and Electoral Integrity

Regulating electoral communication on TikTok is complicated by the distinction between paid advertising and organic participation. TikTok permits users to publish political content organically but prohibits paid political advertising, compensated political creator content and the use of promotional tools by political figures and organisations (TikTok, 2026). However, political communication may still be coordinated, indirectly funded or distributed through creators whose relationship with a campaign is unclear. Giuranno and Manni's (2026) systematic review of 140 studies identifies this as part of a wider governance problem in which engagement-based systems can reward sensational content while restricted data access makes their operation difficult to examine independently. The Westminster Foundation for Democracy and London Social Media Observatory (WFD & LSMO, 2026) similarly argue that TikTok blurs the boundary between entertainment and politics, allowing political narratives to circulate through content that may not resemble conventional campaigning. Platform governance must therefore consider how political visibility is produced and not only whether a post has been formally classified as an advertisement.

The Digital Services Act provides the principal European framework for addressing these wider responsibilities. Under Articles 34 and 35, very large online platforms must assess systemic risks associated with their services and introduce reasonable, proportionate and effective measures to mitigate them. These assessments include the role of recommender systems, advertising systems, content moderation and algorithmic amplification, including where misleading content is not itself illegal but may still contribute to systemic harm (Regulation (EU) 2022/2065, 2022). Article 40 also provides mechanisms for data access and independent scrutiny. The European Commission's electoral guidelines develop these obligations through election-specific recommendations, including cooperation with national authorities and civil society, incident-response procedures, measures concerning generative AI and post-election reviews (European Commission, 2024a). Regulation (EU) 2024/900 adds

a separate layer of accountability for political advertising, and since 10 October 2025, paid or targeted political advertisements must be labelled and disclose information including their sponsor, expenditure and use of targeting techniques. These requirements improve the traceability of formal advertising, but they do not apply in the same way to personal political expression or editorial content. This leaves uncertainty around apparently independent creator commentary, informal endorsements and political messages whose funding or coordination is concealed.

The 2024 Romanian presidential election is relevant because it turned these abstract regulatory concerns into a direct test of the European systemic-risk model. The issue was not limited to whether individual TikTok videos contained prohibited claims. It concerned whether recommendation systems, artificial activity and undisclosed political promotion could collectively alter the conditions under which a candidate became visible. Following concerns about unusual online activity, the European Commission requested information from major platforms about their election-related risk assessments and ordered TikTok to preserve relevant data. On 17 December 2024, it opened formal proceedings concerning TikTok's possible failure to assess and mitigate electoral risks. The investigation focused on its recommender systems, coordinated inauthentic manipulation, automated exploitation, political advertising and paid political content, as well as whether the platform had sufficiently considered the linguistic and regional characteristics of the Romanian election. The proceedings do not establish that TikTok caused a particular electoral result, but they demonstrate why electoral integrity can no longer be evaluated only through traditional campaign-finance and advertising rules.

The difficulty of detecting artificial engagement is not unique to the Romanian case. A controlled experiment conducted by the NATO Strategic Communications Centre of Excellence purchased followers, likes, views, shares and comments from commercial manipulation providers across several platforms, including TikTok, to test whether the platforms could identify and remove them. The researchers found that TikTok removed only a small proportion of the inauthentic accounts and left most of the purchased engagement visible. Because the experiment used non-political content, it does not establish whether such activity can influence electoral visibility or voting behaviour. It nevertheless demonstrates that commercially generated engagement remains widely accessible and may persist within platform metrics despite existing safeguards (Bergmanis-Korāts et al., 2026). Furthermore, a journalistic investigation by Recorder, an independent Romanian investigative media outlet, further illustrated the practical enforcement problem. Using a fictional political candidate and approximately 3,000 false accounts, the experiment reportedly generated one million views,

inflated supportive comments and appeared to trigger TikTok's automated search suggestion. Genuine users could then encounter and interact with visibility that had initially been manufactured. The demonstration cannot establish how commonly this method is used or whether it changes voting decisions, but it shows how artificial engagement can create apparent popularity and initiate subsequent organic circulation (Nedea, 2024).

Effective electoral governance must therefore examine the systems that rank, recommend and legitimise political content, alongside the content itself. European regulation has introduced stronger responsibilities for risk assessment, transparency and independent scrutiny, yet organic promotion, hidden coordination and manufactured engagement remain difficult to identify before they acquire wider visibility.

3. Method and Case Selection

3.1 Sample and Case Selection

This study examines TikTok content associated with Călin Georgescu's campaign before the first round of the 2024 Romanian presidential election. The campaign was selected as an information-rich case through which to investigate how candidate identity, electoral narratives and political visibility can be constructed through short-form video, personal branding and networked circulation. This candidate received limited attention in conventional political reporting and polling before the election, a poll published on 14 November placed him sixth with 5.4 per cent of voting intentions, yet he finished first on 24 November with 2,120,401 votes, representing 22.94 per cent of valid ballots (Fella, 2025).

The campaign is particularly relevant because its communication presented Georgescu's candidacy as more than a conventional electoral offer. He characterised his campaign as not merely political but "a calling" (Ross et al., 2024). This framing positioned the candidacy as a national and moral mission rather than an ordinary competition for political office. His TikTok presence also combined political statements with personal-branding content showing him attending church, practising judo and swimming, a strategy that can be interpreted as contributing to the construction of a cult of personality around a rugged, hyper-masculine strongman imagine (Figure 2). This form of self-presentation can be compared with Vladimir Putin's carefully staged displays of physical strength, including swimming, horse riding and practising martial arts, but it also resembles the broader hyper-masculine digital branding associated with online figures such as Andrew Tate, whose public persona emphasises physical strength, dominance and invulnerability.



Figure 2: A visual comparison of Călin Georgescu and Vladimir Putin in similar public imagery. (Om Europa, 2024)

Furthermore, this campaign is also significant because of its reported connection to scripted influencer-marketing practices. A Snoop investigation found that 130 influencers were recruited through the influencer-marketing platform FameUp and instructed to produce short, daily-vlog-style videos discussing the qualities expected of Romania's future president (Neag et al., 2024). Several creators followed a shared brief containing repeated references to qualities such as balance, seriousness, integrity, experience and patriotism, without explicitly naming Georgescu. These qualities were subsequently connected to him through associated hashtags and coordinated activity in the comment sections.

To define the scope of the analysis, the study covers the period from 1 September to 24 November 2024. The starting date corresponds to Georgescu's public announcement of his candidacy and the beginning of his signature-collection effort (Stan, 2024), while the end date marks the first-round vote. This timeframe ensures that the analysis remains focused on content available to voters before ballots were cast. The final sample consisted of approximately 20 publicly accessible TikTok videos published between 1 September and 24 November 2024. All selected videos will relate directly to Georgescu's candidacy or the wider communication surrounding his campaign. The sample size was chosen to provide sufficient breadth to identify recurring themes and communication patterns, while allowing each video to be examined systematically through template analysis.

3.2 Data Collection and Method of Analysis

The final dataset consisted of 20 TikTok videos associated with the influencer communication examined in this study. Each video was treated as an individual unit of analysis and assigned a unique identifier from T01 to T20. These identifiers are used throughout Chapter 4 when referring to individual videos, quotations and coding examples. Table 3.1 lists the TikTok usernames associated with each identifier.

#	ID	TikTok Username
1	T01	@bettyshor
2	T02	@andreeabld
3	T03	@rebeccaatoma
4	T04	@cristinahorez
5	T05	@braia.robert
6	T06	@biancamitroi1
7	T07	@sivatv
8	T08	@adriana.ciriblan
9	T09	@daiana.jrc
10	T10	@beatrice.nth
11	T11	@bunicalucretia
12	T12	@dragaviitoaremama
13	T13	@denisa.asmr22
14	T14	@beatriceadriana1
15	T15	@madalinaastefanoai
16	T16	@adina_miuleasa
17	T17	@n.deniscristian
18	T18	@bellap1993
19	T19	@roxanaroxi302
20	T20	@madelainne19

Table 3.2: TikTok identifiers and usernames used within the analysis

The use of identifiers provided a consistent method of tracing analytical observations back to the corresponding source material while avoiding repeated use of lengthy usernames throughout the findings chapter. The identifiers do not indicate any ranking or chronological importance within the sample.

The dataset was assembled from a combination of original TikTok material, recovered video segments, transcripts and supplementary Exolyt records. Exolyt is a third-party TikTok analytics platform that provides data on TikTok videos, accounts, hashtags and engagement performance. Usable transcript material was available for all 20 videos, while Exolyt records were available for 15. Exolyt data were used to provide supplementary information such as upload dates, captions, hashtags and engagement metrics, but were not used as the primary method of content analysis. The availability of the original audiovisual material varied because a number of TikTok posts had been removed or were no longer directly accessible. Where an original or recovered version of a video could be identified, the relevant influencer segment was retained for analysis. Where a video appeared within reaction or archival material, surrounding commentary was excluded so that only the identifiable content of the original TikTok was analysed. Deleted or unavailable posts were not interpreted as evidence of any particular intention, and their disappearance was instead recorded as a limitation of the dataset.

As the sampled content was primarily in Romanian, the source transcripts were retained in Romanian throughout the coding process. English was used for analytical codes, theme labels, notes and dissertation reporting. Relevant extracts were translated into English when presented in Chapter 4. Direct quotations selected for reporting were checked against the available original or recovered audiovisual material where possible to reduce the risk of relying on transcription errors or overly loose translations. The Romanian source wording was therefore treated as the primary textual record during analysis.

Template Analysis was selected as the principal method for examining the videos because it provides a structured but flexible approach to identifying recurring patterns within qualitative data. Rather than requiring a fixed coding framework to be established before analysis, Template Analysis allows preliminary codes to be developed, grouped into broader clusters and progressively reorganised into a hierarchical template of themes and sub-themes. Tabari, King and Egan (2020) describe the process as iterative: an initial template is applied to further data and subsequently revised where themes do not adequately represent the material. Themes may therefore be added, removed, renamed or reorganised as the analysis develops. This flexibility was suitable for the present study because the aim was to identify recurring communication strategies across the TikTok sample rather than test a predetermined set of categories.

The analysis began with an initial reading of the transcripts to identify recurring statements, message structures and communication techniques relevant to the research question. Coding focused on how presidential suitability was described, how creators positioned themselves in relation to the election, how political dissatisfaction and change were expressed, and how viewers were addressed or encouraged to participate. These observations were recorded as preliminary codes rather than being treated immediately as final themes.

Related codes were then grouped into broader clusters. For example, recurring references to honesty, seriousness, integrity and a clean political history were grouped around ideas of moral legitimacy, while references to education, professional experience and previous achievements were grouped around competence and demonstrated capacity. Other recurring codes concerned patriotism, actions rather than promises, non-influence disclaimers, dissatisfaction with existing politics, calls for change and direct encouragement to vote. This process allowed individual statements to be compared across the full dataset rather than analysed as isolated examples.

An initial analytical template was subsequently developed from these clusters. Template Analysis uses hierarchical coding, meaning that narrower patterns can be organised beneath broader themes while still retaining distinctions between related concepts (Tabari, King and Egan, 2020). The template was then applied across all 20 videos and revised iteratively. Where a code did not fit clearly within the emerging structure, its definition and relationship with other codes were reconsidered. Closely related categories were merged where they represented the same underlying pattern, while distinctions were retained where they described analytically different forms of communication.

For example, statements that a president should fulfil promises were coded as characteristics of presidential suitability, whereas expressions such as being tired of political promises were treated as dissatisfaction with existing politics. This distinction prevented similar vocabulary from being automatically assigned to the same theme when it performed a different function within the video. A video could also be coded under more than one sub-theme where different parts of the content clearly represented separate patterns.

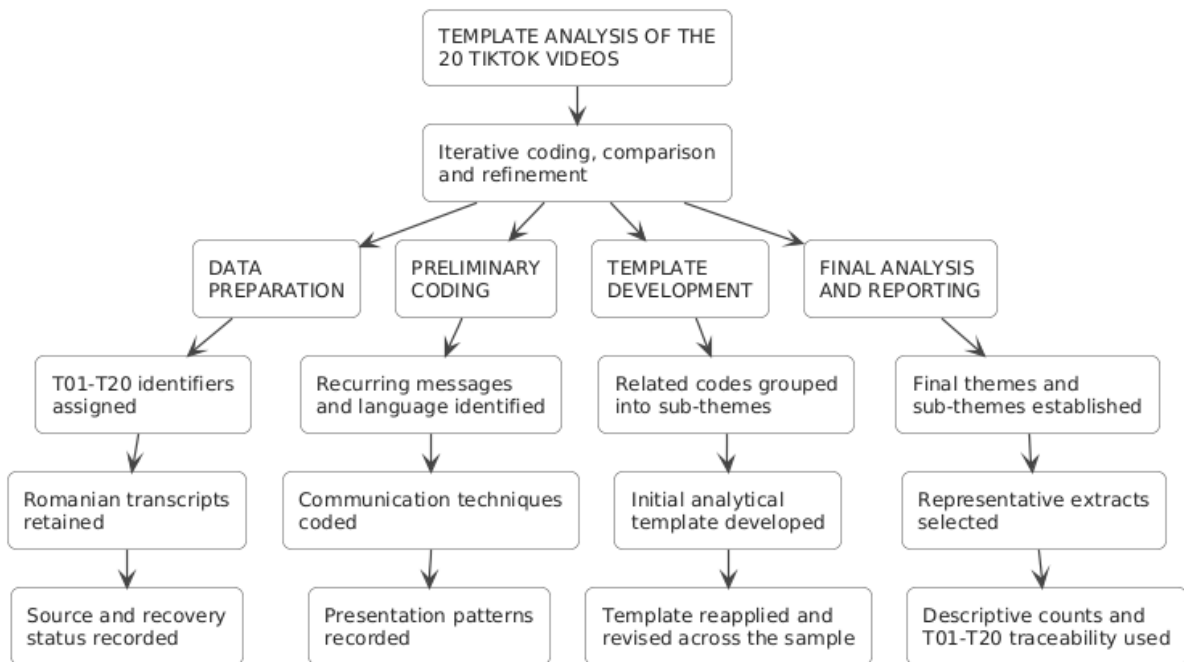


Figure 3: Template Analysis Process Used in this Study

The final template contained four overarching themes: Constructing the Ideal President; Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement; Dissatisfaction and Desire for Change; and Audience Engagement and Voting Mobilisation. These were supported by a series of more specific sub-themes used to organise the findings presented in Sections 4.2 to 4.5. The themes therefore emerged through repeated coding and refinement across the dataset rather than being imposed as fixed categories before the analysis began. The workbook used during coding retained the original transcript, preliminary coding, representative extracts and the final theme allocation for each video, providing a traceable record of how the final structure was developed. The completed analysis included all 20 transcripts and produced four main themes and 14 working sub-themes.

Frequency counts were also recorded for each final sub-theme to indicate how widely a particular pattern appeared within the 20-video sample. These counts are used descriptively in Chapter 4, for example to distinguish patterns present across most of the dataset from those appearing in a smaller number of videos. They should not be interpreted as statistical estimates of the wider TikTok campaign or of Romanian political communication more generally. The purpose of the counts was to support transparency within the qualitative analysis, while the interpretation remained based on the wording, context and communication patterns contained within the videos.

4. Findings and Analysis

The aim of this analysis is to examine how electoral communication associated with Călin Georgescu's 2024 presidential campaign was constructed and circulated through TikTok, with particular attention to candidate positioning, influencer-based communication, emotional and national framing audience engagement. Using Template Analysis, the sampled TikTok content was examined for recurring patterns in language, message construction and communication style.

Before presenting the themes identified through Template Analysis, Section 4.1 examines the wider campaign structure surrounding the sampled content, focusing on the organised influencer promotion and the way this communication was presented through individual TikTok creators. The Template Analysis itself identified four overarching themes: Constructing the Ideal President; Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement; Dissatisfaction and Desire for Change; and Audience Engagement and Voting Mobilisation. These themes were developed through the iterative coding and refinement of recurring patterns across the sample rather than being treated as predetermined categories. Figure 3 provides a visual overview of the four themes and their related sub-themes.

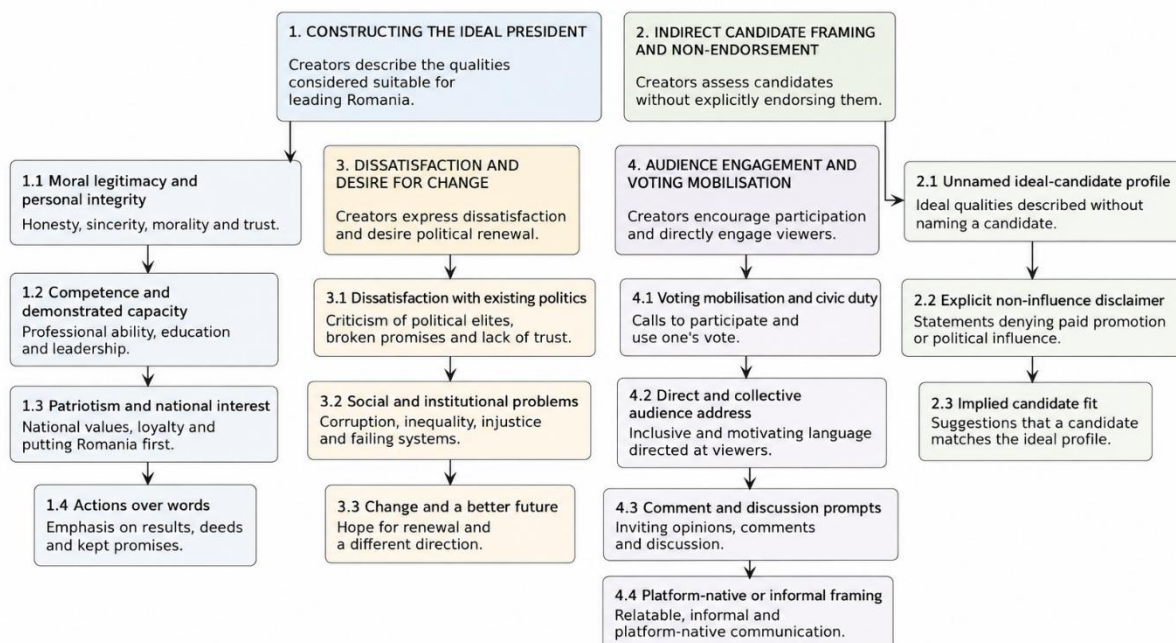


Figure 4: Visual Map of Themes and Sub-themes

4.1 Campaign Structure and Influencer Promotion

The sampled TikTok content formed part of a wider influencer-marketing environment surrounding the 2024 presidential election. As discussed in Chapter 3, a Snoop investigation identified a paid FameUp campaign in which creators were encouraged to discuss the qualities expected of Romania's future president (Neag et al., 2024). Of particular relevance to this analysis is the way this organised communication was presented through the conventions of personal TikTok content.

Importantly, the influencer guidance did not require creators to reproduce an identical script. The document presented a series of suggested ideas concerning the qualities expected of Romania's future president, while also encouraging creators to remain authentic and produce content in the style their followers were already familiar with (Neag et al., 2024). This is relevant when considering the variation across the sampled videos. Creators used different wording, examples and additional qualities while recurring ideas concerning presidential suitability remained visible across the sample. The guidance therefore provides useful context for understanding how a shared campaign direction could be adapted to individual creator styles, without assuming that every creator reproduced the same message in the same way.

Rather than delivering explicit electoral endorsements, creators frequently framed the subject as a personal discussion about the presidential election. In one sampled video, the creator states that she does not want to influence viewers and does not want them to follow her opinion, before introducing "my opinion" about the criteria according to which she would choose a president. Another creator similarly introduces the discussion by saying that she will "share my opinion" before describing the qualities required of a political leader. This distinction between the organised origin of the communication and its presentation as individual creator opinion is important from a digital media perspective. The political message becomes embedded within familiar creator conventions such as direct-to-camera speech, personal reflection and audience discussion, rather than appearing in the recognisable form of a conventional political advertisement. The result is a form of indirect political communication in which the promotional structure may be less immediately visible to the audience than the creator's individual persona.

This combination of coordinated campaign guidance and content presented through individual creator voices can be understood through the concept of astroturfing. Astroturfing refers to the artificial generation or coordination of communication in a way that creates the appearance of spontaneous or grassroots activity. In this case, the concept is useful for examining how paid

or coordinated influencer communication could be presented through apparently independent creator voices.

4.2 Constructing the Ideal President

The most consistent pattern identified across the sample was the construction of a recognisable image of the ideal president. Rather than focusing primarily on detailed policy proposals or party positions, the videos repeatedly presented presidential suitability through personal qualities, professional experience, patriotism and evidence of previous achievement. Four closely related patterns contributed to this representation, as summarised in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2: Sub-themes within “Constructing the Ideal President”

Sub-theme	How it appeared in the content	Number of sampled videos coded with sub-theme
Moral legitimacy and personal integrity	Honesty, seriousness, balance, integrity, discipline and a clean political record	20/20
Competence and demonstrated capacity	Education, professional experience, leadership ability and previous achievements	19/20
Patriotism and national interest	Love of Romania, prioritising the country and representing the interests of Romanians	12/20
Actions over words	Previous achievements and concrete actions contrasted with promises and political rhetoric	11/20

The videos frequently combined several of these characteristics rather than presenting them separately. Honesty, seriousness and competence, for example, were often discussed alongside education and professional experience. One creator described the desired president as “honest, patriotic, well educated, family-oriented, a good leader, serious and correct” (T13), while another called for someone “balanced, serious, patriotic, honest, disciplined, with principles and authentic values” (T15). The resulting image was therefore not simply that of an honest politician, but of a candidate whose moral character and professional credibility were presented as mutually reinforcing.

Professional competence was often presented through education, previous experience and prior achievement. Rather than discussing specific policies, several creators focused on whether a future president had the preparation and experience required for the role. One video called for “a leader with a solid career, real studies, someone who understands very well how

state institutions work and respects them” (T12). Another questioned candidates with an “empty CV”, contrasting this with experience and previous achievements (T04). Across the sample, competence was therefore communicated through relatively simple indicators that could be easily recognised by viewers, such as education, career experience and evidence of previous success. This pattern appeared in 19 of the 20 sampled videos, making it one of the most consistent elements of the ideal presidential profile.

Patriotism and the national interest were also frequently connected to this profile. In 12 of the 20 videos, the desired president was associated with caring about Romania, representing Romanians and placing the interests of the country above personal interests. For example, one creator described patriotism and honesty as “essential” (T12), while another argued that a future president should be “patriotic and put the country first” (T18). This framing connected personal character with national responsibility, suggesting that a suitable president should not only appear competent and honest, but should also demonstrate that their priorities were aligned with those of the country.

A similar pattern appeared in the repeated contrast between actions and words. Eleven videos contained some form of this distinction, usually presenting previous achievements or fulfilled promises as evidence of authenticity. One of the clearest examples stated: “We are tired of words; we want actions” (T15). Another argued that the president should have “demonstrated his qualities through actions, not through words and false promises” (T02). Rather than treating political promises as sufficient, these videos framed credibility as something that should already have been demonstrated before the election.

The consistency of these characteristics becomes particularly relevant when compared with the influencer brief discussed in Chapter 3. The original brief proposed qualities including a “serious and balanced” president, a candidate free from corruption scandals, patriotism demonstrated “through actions, not words”, and someone who had already achieved something for Romania. Similar wording or closely related ideas appeared across multiple creators in the analysed sample. For example, the pairing of seriousness and balance appeared across six sampled videos, while the idea of patriotism demonstrated through actions was reflected in several others. The similarity between the brief and the analysed content does not, by itself, establish the intentions of every individual creator. However, it shows that the ideal presidential profile identified through the Template Analysis closely corresponded with the qualities contained in the documented influencer campaign.

Taken together, the videos constructed a relatively consistent image of presidential suitability based on personal integrity, competence, patriotism and demonstrated achievement. Political choice was therefore often presented through a recognisable set of personal qualities rather than through detailed comparison of policies or party programmes. From a digital media perspective, this reduced the idea of presidential suitability to a concise and repeatable profile that could be communicated quickly through short-form video and reproduced across different creators. The significance of this becomes clearer when considering that the creators generally discussed these qualities without directly naming the candidate they were describing, which forms the focus of the following section.

4.3 Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement

A notable feature across the sample was that creators described in considerable detail what Romania's future president should be like without directly naming a preferred candidate. This pattern appeared across all 20 sampled videos. Rather than communicating candidate preference through an explicit endorsement, the videos generally established criteria against which the presidential candidates could be evaluated. In a smaller number of cases, creators explicitly stated that they were not attempting to influence viewers, while several videos suggested that a candidate matching the described profile could nevertheless be identified.

Table 4.3: Sub-themes within "Candidate Evaluation Without Direct Endorsement"

Sub-theme	How it appeared in the content	Number of sampled videos coded with sub-theme
Unnamed ideal-candidate profile	Creators described the qualities expected of a president without directly naming a preferred candidate	20/20
Explicit non-influence disclaimer	Creators stated that they were not attempting to influence viewers or tell them whom to vote for	3/20
Implied candidate fit	The wording suggested that a candidate matching the described profile could be identified without naming that person	5/20

The unnamed candidate profile was the most consistent element of this theme. Although the videos discussed presidential qualities extensively, the preferred candidate remained unnamed throughout the sampled influencer content. This created a distinction between

defining what a suitable president should represent and explicitly identifying who fulfilled those expectations. The qualities identified in Section 4.2 therefore functioned not only as descriptions of ideal leadership, but also as criteria that could be applied when considering the candidates available in the election.

As discussed in Section 4.1, three creators reinforced this position through explicit statements that they were not attempting to influence viewers. T02, T08 and T14 were coded with this pattern. In T14, for example, the creator stated that she was not there to “influence your opinion in the vote” and emphasised that the decision belonged entirely to the viewer. She then continued by discussing the need for an honest president with a clean political history, previous achievements, national priorities and a balanced approach. The importance of these statements is therefore not that they removed political content from the videos, but that they allowed candidate evaluation to be framed as an individual decision while a detailed set of desirable qualities was still being communicated.

In five of the sampled videos, the relationship between the established criteria and the process of choosing a candidate became more explicit. These were T04, T07, T08, T14 and T18. After describing the preferred president as honest, educated, family-oriented, concerned with Romania and “one of us”, the creator concluded that they believed they could find “a candidate like this among the 14”. The statement moves from describing desirable qualities to considering whether one of the available candidates fulfils them.

A similar pattern appeared in T18. The creator first described the future president as honest, educated, empathetic, patriotic and willing to place the country first, before stating: “I want us to find together a candidate who has all these qualities”. Candidate selection is again presented as a process of identifying the person who best corresponds with an already established profile. Importantly, the candidate is still not directly named. The viewer is instead positioned as someone who can participate in evaluating which candidate appears to satisfy the criteria being discussed.

T14 provides another example of this separation between criteria and final candidate choice. After presenting a detailed presidential profile, the creator stated that she already had “a few people in mind” but was not yet completely certain whom she would vote for. This reinforces the presentation of the criteria as a basis for evaluation rather than an explicit instruction to support a particular individual.

Taken together, these examples suggest that candidate preference within the sampled content was often communicated through evaluation rather than direct endorsement. The videos established a relatively consistent picture of presidential suitability and then left the preferred candidate unnamed, allowing the audience to consider which of the available candidates appeared to correspond with that profile. In several cases, creators directly referred to the process of finding or considering a candidate who met the stated criteria.

4.4 Dissatisfaction and Desire for Change

Another recurring pattern across the sample was dissatisfaction with existing politics and a desire for change. In several videos, the qualities expected of a future president were discussed against frustration with political promises, dishonesty or a perceived lack of results. Other creators connected the election with wider social concerns or with hopes for a better future. Three related patterns were identified within this theme, as summarised in Table 4.4.

Table 4.4: Sub-themes within “Dissatisfaction and Desire for Change”

Sub-theme	How it appeared in the content	Number of sampled videos coded with sub-theme
Dissatisfaction with existing politics	Frustration with lies, empty promises, political performance or a perceived lack of results	6/20
Social and institutional problems	References to living conditions, education, health, economic or social concerns and wider institutional problems	4/20
Change and a better future	Calls for change, progress, improvement and a better future for Romania	10/20

Dissatisfaction with existing politics appeared explicitly in six of the 20 sampled videos. T08 brings this dissatisfaction together with the type of political alternative being sought. The creator states:

“We are tired of words, promises and lies... This time we want a candidate who has actually done something for Romania, not someone who is playing a role... We want a serious president, a patriotic president...” (T08, translated)

This dissatisfaction was closely connected to the distinction between actions and words identified in Section 4.2, but it performed a different role within these videos. In the construction

of the ideal president, previous achievement provided evidence that a candidate was capable and credible. Here, references to promises, lies and political talk established a negative comparison with which that ideal profile could be contrasted. Qualities such as honesty, reliability and demonstrated action therefore acquired additional meaning when positioned against dissatisfaction with existing political behaviour.

The contrast was particularly visible where creators moved directly from criticism to describing an alternative. T08 followed frustration with political promises and lies by calling for a serious and patriotic president who had already done something for Romania. T15 similarly stated that people were “tired of words” and wanted actions, while presenting the desired president as serious, honest, disciplined and demonstrated through previous achievement. In these cases, dissatisfaction did not function as a separate political argument. Instead, it helped establish why the qualities associated with the desired president were presented as necessary.

Broader social and institutional problems appeared less frequently, in four of the 20 videos. This was therefore a secondary pattern within the sample rather than a dominant feature. Where these concerns did appear, however, the discussion extended beyond dissatisfaction with politicians themselves. T09 opened by suggesting that people working in areas such as agriculture and medicine would have aspects of their lives with which they were dissatisfied, before presenting the presidential election as an opportunity to make a change. T11 referred more specifically to the need for greater involvement in education and healthcare and for greater support for both systems.

Other examples connected political leadership with broader questions concerning living conditions, equality and the future of people in Romania. These references allowed large political or institutional concerns to be expressed through relatively simple and recognisable examples. Rather than presenting detailed policy arguments, the videos connected the presidential election with issues that could be understood through everyday experiences such as work, public services and the ability to build a future in the country. This was consistent with the wider communication style of the sample, in which complex questions of presidential suitability were frequently condensed into short lists of qualities, problems and aspirations suitable for brief creator-led videos.

The most common pattern within this theme was the presentation of change and a better future, appearing in ten of the 20 sampled videos. In T03, dissatisfaction with political talk was immediately followed by the invitation to “change Romania’s future together”. T09 similarly described the approaching election as a significant opportunity “for all of us to make a change

in our lives". In both examples, change was presented collectively, connecting an individual electoral decision with a wider idea of national improvement.

Other creators presented the future in more aspirational terms. T05 stated that "we want to live in a country we can be proud of", connecting the desired president with national progress rather than simply the replacement of an existing political figure. T15 and T19 referred to the hope that Romanians living abroad might return home, positioning political improvement in relation to migration and the future of the country. T20 similarly connected leadership with future generations and the need for young people to have reasons to remain in Romania. The meaning of change therefore varied across the sample but repeatedly involved the idea that political leadership could be evaluated according to the future it appeared capable of representing. This created a broader contrast across the sampled communication. Existing politics could be associated with promises, disappointment or perceived problems, while the desired alternative was associated with honesty, competence, demonstrated action and improvement. This reflects the contrast between decline and renewal discussed in Chapter 2, although the present theme was developed from recurring patterns within the analysed videos rather than being imposed as a predetermined category.

The significance of this pattern is also visible in the way similar ideas could be communicated through different creator voices. Individual videos used different examples and levels of criticism, yet dissatisfaction and change repeatedly appeared alongside the ideal presidential qualities identified earlier in the analysis. Short-form creator content therefore provided a format in which political dissatisfaction, candidate expectations and future aspirations could be combined into relatively concise and accessible messages.

Overall, the sampled videos did not only communicate what a desirable president should be like. A smaller but notable part of the content also established what viewers might wish to move away from, while a larger group presented the election in relation to change and a different future. This contrast between dissatisfaction and aspiration helped provide a wider context for the ideal presidential profile identified in the previous sections.

4.5 Audience Engagement and Voting Mobilisation

The sampled videos also encouraged viewers to take part in the electoral discussion rather than simply receive information about presidential candidates. Creators addressed viewers directly, referred to political choices through collective language and, in several cases,

encouraged them to vote or contribute their own opinions. Some videos also used informal forms of communication more typical of TikTok than of conventional political campaigning.

Table 4.5: Sub-themes within “Audience Engagement and Voting Mobilisation

Sub-theme	How it appeared in the content	Number of sampled videos coded with sub-theme
Voting mobilisation and civic duty	Direct encouragement to vote or references to voting as a right, responsibility or important choice	11/20
Direct and collective audience address	Direct and collective audience address	20/20
Comment and discussion prompts	Viewers are asked to share their opinions or presidential criteria in the comments	6/20
Platform-native or informal framing	Political discussion is presented through informal language, dialogue, humour or familiar TikTok-style comparisons	7/20

Voting mobilisation appeared in 11 of the 20 sampled videos. Calls to vote were often placed at the end of a discussion about presidential qualities, creating a movement from evaluating leadership to encouraging electoral participation. T01 told viewers to “be the change you want to see in this country” and to be the person who goes out to vote, while T03 ended its discussion of presidential qualities and political change with the direct instruction “Come and vote”. T19 similarly concluded with “You should go and vote too” after describing the qualities expected of a president and expressing a desire for actions rather than words. These calls were generally short and direct, giving the videos a clear action for the viewer to take once the desired presidential profile had been established.

Voting was not always presented simply as an instruction. In T20, it was framed as a civic right connected to previous generations, with the creator stating that voting was important because “our ancestors fought for us to have this right”. The video then moves into a discussion of the qualities expected of a presidential candidate and the creator’s desire for change. Electoral participation was therefore connected not only with candidate preference but also with a wider sense of responsibility and the importance of making a considered political choice.

Direct and collective audience address was present across all 20 videos. The repeated use of words such as “you”, “we” and “us” positioned the viewer within the discussion rather than

outside it. T03, for example, moves from “if you are also tired of words” to “let us change Romania’s future together”, shifting from the viewer’s individual frustration to a collective idea of political change. T19 repeatedly uses “we want” and “we need” when describing presidential qualities before ending with a direct instruction to the viewer to vote. This style made the discussion of presidential leadership feel less like a detached description of politics and more like a shared consideration of what “we” should expect from the next president.

The same collective language also appeared when creators encouraged viewers to participate in defining the desired candidate. Six videos explicitly asked for opinions or responses in the comments. T09 asked viewers to write their views in the comments after discussing honesty and leadership, while T16 directly asked what qualities viewers believed a president should have. T17 similarly invited followers to describe their own presidential profile. In T18, the creator combined collective candidate evaluation with a direct request for participation, stating that “I want us to find together a candidate who has all these qualities” before asking viewers to add their own criteria in the comments.

These prompts are relevant because they extend the message beyond the creator’s own opinion. The viewer is invited to repeat, reconsider or add to the criteria being discussed. The videos therefore did not always present the ideal-president profile as a finished statement. In some cases, it was presented as a question that followers could participate in answering. This does not demonstrate that viewers accepted the criteria or were influenced by them, but it shows that interaction was built into the way part of the campaign-related content was communicated.

A further seven videos were coded for informal or platform-native framing. Rather than adopting the tone of a traditional political advertisement, these videos used conversational language, humour, dialogue or comparisons drawn from everyday digital culture. T04 illustrates this particularly well by presenting the selection of a president through the language of dating and relationships:

“If you talk a lot and your CV is empty, next!... We need a president, not a reality-show star... we don’t need another toxic relationship for five years... among the 14, we can find one to swipe right on, if he’s suitable.” (T04, translated)

The presidential election is presented here through concepts such as “swipe right”, relationships and a “reality-show star”. Candidate evaluation is therefore translated into a

familiar style of online conversation while retaining many of the same criteria identified elsewhere in the sample, including experience, achievement, seriousness and patriotism.

This type of presentation is important when considering how political messages can sit alongside everyday creator content. The distinction between entertainment and political communication becomes less obvious when an election is discussed using the same conversational styles and cultural references that viewers encounter elsewhere on TikTok. This reflects the discussion in Chapter 2 concerning TikTok's ability to blur entertainment and politics, allowing political narratives to circulate through content that may not resemble conventional campaigning (WFD & LSMO, 2026).

Across the sample, audience participation was therefore built into the communication in several ways. Viewers were addressed directly, included within collective ideas about Romania and its future, asked to contribute their own opinions and, in more than half of the videos, encouraged to vote. Informal TikTok-style communication also allowed electoral discussion to be presented through familiar creator language rather than through the conventions of a traditional campaign message. These findings do not establish whether the videos changed voting behaviour, but they show how presidential criteria, dissatisfaction and calls for change could be connected with audience participation within short-form social media content.

5. Conclusions

5.1 Conclusion and Synthesis of Findings

This study examined how electoral communication associated with Călin Georgescu's 2024 presidential campaign was constructed through TikTok, with particular attention to the relationship between political marketing, influencer communication and platform-native content. The analysis of 20 TikTok videos identified a consistent pattern in which political messages were presented less as conventional candidate promotion and more as personal discussions about the qualities Romania's future president should possess. This occurred within a wider influencer campaign that provided creators with shared guidance while allowing them to adapt the message to their own communication style.

The most consistent finding was the construction of a recognisable presidential profile based on honesty, competence, patriotism and demonstrated achievement. These qualities appeared repeatedly across different creators and were generally communicated without

naming a preferred candidate. All 20 videos contained an unnamed ideal-candidate profile, while several creators explicitly stated that they were not attempting to influence viewers. The content therefore separated the construction of presidential criteria from the direct identification of the candidate who might satisfy them.

This distinction is important for understanding how indirect electoral influence may operate. Rather than requiring repeated instructions to support a particular candidate, the communication first established a set of qualities through which presidential suitability could be judged. Audiences could subsequently apply those criteria when considering the available candidates. In several videos, this process was made more visible when creators referred to finding or identifying a candidate who matched the profile, while still leaving that individual unnamed.

The remaining themes strengthened this evaluative structure. Dissatisfaction with existing politics, social problems and a desire for change created a contrast between the political present and the type of leadership being presented as desirable. At the same time, direct audience address, comment prompts and calls to vote transformed candidate evaluation into a participatory form of TikTok communication. The findings therefore suggest that electoral influence on the platform may involve more than explicit endorsement. It may also operate through the repeated construction of political criteria, their adaptation into familiar creator communication, and the invitation for audiences to participate in evaluating which candidate appears to fulfil them.

This does not demonstrate that the sampled content changed voting behaviour. It instead identifies a communication process through which electoral preferences could potentially be shaped.

5.2 Proposed Strategic Framework for Analysing Electoral Influence on TikTok

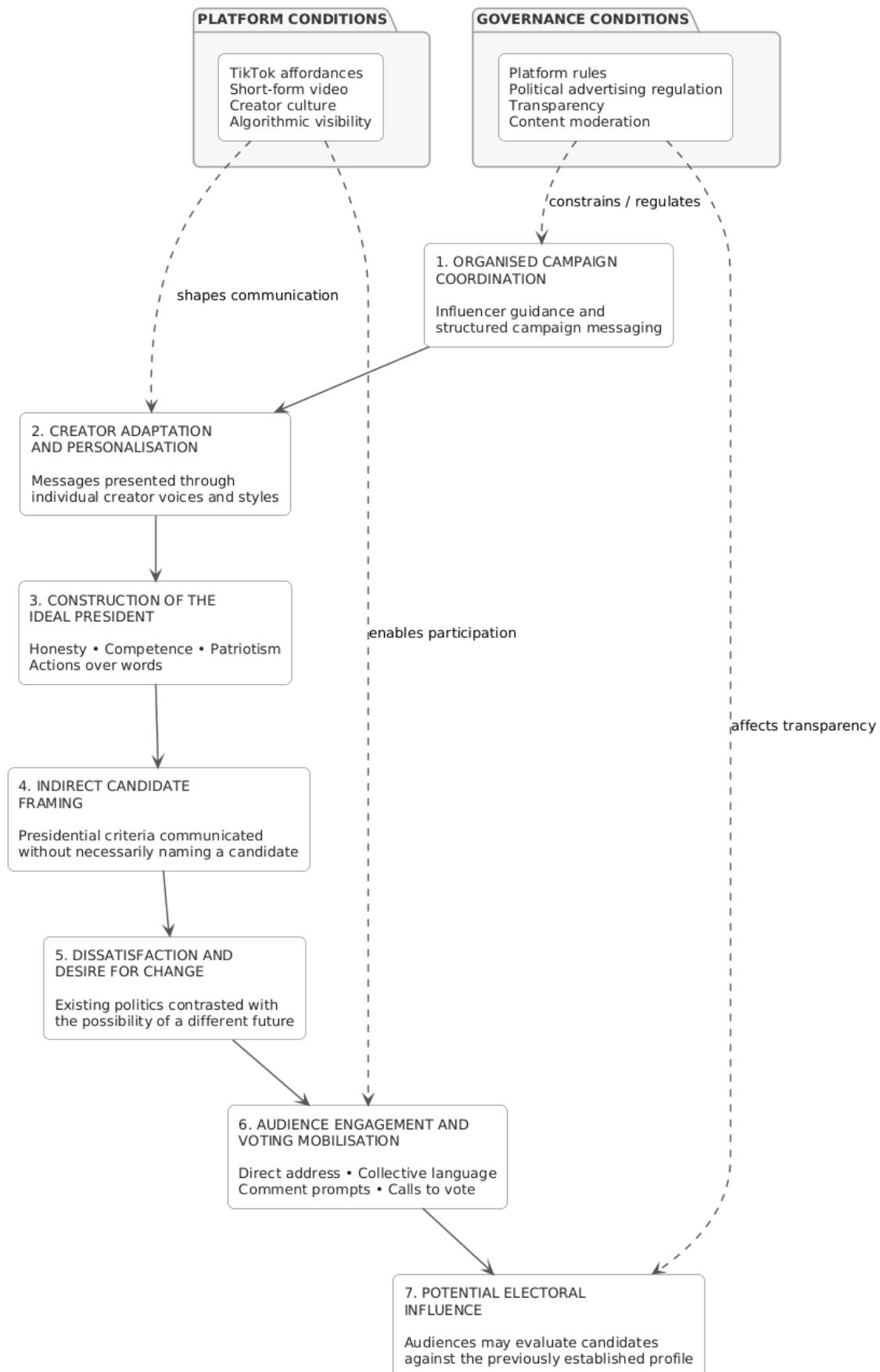
The findings support a strategic framework in which electoral influence can develop through several connected stages rather than through direct candidate endorsement alone. The proposed process begins with organised campaign coordination, which in this case can be considered through the lens of astroturfing. Astroturfing involves coordinated activity, including paid influencers, being used to create communication that appears more spontaneous or independently generated. The documented FameUp campaign provides the starting point for this model, as influencers were recruited to communicate similar ideas about the qualities of the future president while adapting them to their own creator styles.

The analysis suggests that this initial coordination can then move through creator adaptation and criteria construction. Across the sample, qualities such as honesty, competence, patriotism and demonstrated action were repeatedly presented as characteristics of the ideal president, generally without naming a candidate. The audience was therefore given a set of criteria through which candidates could subsequently be evaluated. Dissatisfaction with existing politics and calls for change further strengthened the contrast between the current political situation and the type of leadership being presented as desirable.

The framework also proposes a possible transition from astroturfing to organic or grassroots mobilisation. If initially coordinated messages resonate with existing frustrations, values or aspirations, users may begin to repeat, discuss and circulate those ideas voluntarily. At this stage, the campaign would no longer depend entirely on paid creators because parts of the message could be reproduced through genuine audience participation. This study does not directly demonstrate that such a transition occurred or measure why users shared particular messages, so this stage should be understood as a potential mechanism suggested by the communication pattern, rather than a proven audience effect.

The resulting framework therefore represents electoral influence as a progression from organised coordination, through creator personalisation and construction of political criteria, towards audience participation, potential organic amplification and candidate evaluation.

Strategic Framework for Analysing Electoral Influence on TikTok



5.3 Limitations and Future Research

The study has several limitations that also create opportunities for future research. Template Analysis was appropriate for identifying recurring patterns across the 20-video sample, but its emphasis on cross-case themes inevitably provides less detailed attention to each individual video. This is a recognised limitation of Template Analysis, where the focus on similarities across cases can reduce the holistic understanding of individual accounts (Tabari, King and Egan, 2020). A more in-depth approach, such as multimodal discourse analysis or semiotic analysis, could therefore complement the present findings by examining how language, tone of voice, visual presentation, editing, body language and direct audience address contribute to the persuasive meaning of individual TikTok videos. Such an approach would require a smaller sample because of the greater level of detail involved.

Data availability also limited the study. Several original TikTok posts had been deleted or were no longer directly accessible, requiring identifiable influencer segments to be recovered through archival and reaction material where possible. This restricted the extent to which audiovisual features could be examined consistently across every video. TikTok's limited researcher access and opaque recommendation system also make it difficult to reconstruct precisely how content travelled between users.

Future research could therefore combine the qualitative framework developed here with network or platform-level analysis to examine how messages spread between creators, hashtags and audiences over time. This would be particularly useful for testing the proposed transition from coordinated astroturfing to organic grassroots amplification. Audience interviews, surveys or comment analysis could further investigate whether viewers recognised the coordination, associated the repeated presidential criteria with a particular candidate, and voluntarily reproduced those messages. Applying the framework to other elections would also help determine which stages are specific to the Romanian case and which may occur more broadly on TikTok.

Appendix

Appendix A. Influencer Brief (Translated)

Machine Translated by Google

INITIALLY PROPOSED VARIANT

Influencer Brief No. 2

Objective

Promoting the theme: **What kind of president do you want for Romania?**

swell

On November 24, presidential elections will take place in our country, a topic that is already being discussed a lot in the press and on social networks.

Many of us rightly wonder what kind of president would be suitable for Romania.

The presidential race is tight, there are 14 presidential candidates, but not all of them are equally experienced or equally prepared for the position of president. They also differ in terms of the support they enjoy.

We want to discuss more about the profile needed for the future president of Romania and people's expectations regarding him.

What do you need to do?

1. Make a 30-50 second daily vlog video, in which you talk to your community about the qualities that matter to someone running for president of Romania.
2. Talk about the experience necessary for this position (for example, having previously held other public positions, knowledge of the institutions of the Romanian state, but also of international institutions, a relevant professional career), but also about the personal qualities that a candidate must have (e.g. seriousness, fairness, balance, ability to dialogue, knowledge of foreign languages, etc.)
3. Explain to your community that not all candidates are the same and that some are more qualified for the position, while others lack the necessary training. It is therefore important for people to weigh and choose carefully.
4. You can also get inspiration from the following ideas:
 - We want a serious and balanced president.
 - We need a fair man, who cannot be linked to corruption scandals.
 - We need to have a president who demonstrated patriotism through deeds, not words.

INITIALLY PROPOSED VARIANT

- People are waiting for a candidate who has already done something for Romania. Not just someone who speaks interestingly, but someone who has some results in his activity so far.
- It is important that the president has the support of a strong party. This is the case in all countries, including America. It is difficult to lead the country if you do not have partners in Parliament, in the Government, in the local administration.

Target audience

- People between the ages of 35 and 60, all levels of education, both urban and rural from rural areas, both men and women

Tips for impactful content:

- Don't rush the filming or slow it down.
- Be authentic, create your videos in the style your followers are used to.
- Film yourself using your phone's app, not directly from the social media app. The quality of the clip is strongly influenced by this aspect.
- Shoot the clip in good quality. The clip should be in focus, not pixelated and without blur.
- Make sure you can hear and see yourself clearly.
- Avoid adding too much text to the clip
- Add appropriate hashtags (e.g. **#Presidential2024 #APresidentForRomania #BalanceAndSeriousness**)

Post the materials during the decided period, at the best times to get maximum views.

Appendix B. Dataset and Evidence Overview

Table A1. Sample composition and available metrics

ID	Creator	Upload date	Views	Engagement	Transcript	Exolyt	Evidence
T01	Bettyshor	10 November 2024	90,500	7.0%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T02	Andreeabld	—	—	—	Yes	No	Transcript only
T03	Rebecca Toma	9 November 2024	263,200	9.1%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T04	Cristina Horez	3 November 2024	9,800	2.6%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T05	Braia Robert	4 November 2024	95,900	1.8%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T06	Bianca Mitroi	—	—	—	Yes	No	Transcript only
T07	Sicatv	—	—	—	Yes	No	Transcript only
T08	Adriana Cirişlan	2 November 2024	320,400	4.0%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T09	Daiana Jrc	8 November 2024	18,000	11.4%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T10	Beatrice Nth	—	—	—	Yes	No	Transcript only
T11	Bunica Lucretia	—	—	—	Yes	No	Transcript only
T12	DragaViitoareMama	3 November 2024	10,900	0.5%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T13	Denisa Asmr	7 November 2024	47,600	3.0%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T14	Beatrice Adriana	7 November 2024	17,600	5.3%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T15	Madalina	6 November 2024	20,400	2.2%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T16	Adina Miuleasa	7 November 2024	9,900	3.9%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T17	Nitu Denis	9 November 2024	2,500	2.3%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T18	Bella Caramela	10 November 2024	4,500	9.7%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T19	Roxana	9 November 2024	48,000	12.3%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt
T20	Madalina19	9 November 2024	4,400	2.8%	Yes	Yes	Transcript + Exolyt

Note. All 20 sampled videos have transcript evidence; Exolyt metrics are available for 15. A dash indicates that the workbook did not contain a metric. Some original TikToks were unavailable and were analysed through identifiable recovered material, as explained in the methodology chapter.

Appendix C. Final Template-Analysis Framework

Table B1. Final themes, sub-themes, definitions and sample coverage

Theme and sub-theme	Operational meaning	TikTok IDs coded	n
1. Constructing the Ideal President 1.1 Moral legitimacy and personal integrity	Honesty, seriousness, balance, integrity, discipline, empathy and other moral qualities.	T01; T02; T03; T04; T05; T06; T07; T08; T09; T10; T11; T12; T13; T14; T15; T16; T17; T18; T19; T20	20
1. Constructing the Ideal President 1.2 Competence and demonstrated capacity	Education, experience, leadership, knowledge and previous achievements.	T02; T03; T04; T05; T06; T07; T08; T09; T10; T11; T12; T13; T14; T15; T16; T17; T18; T19; T20	19
1. Constructing the Ideal President 1.3 Patriotism and national interest	Love of Romania, putting the country first and prioritising public over personal interests.	T02; T04; T05; T06; T07; T08; T11; T12; T13; T14; T15; T18	12
1. Constructing the Ideal President 1.4 Actions over words	Actions, results and previous achievements are valued over promises or political talk.	T02; T03; T04; T08; T10; T11; T13; T14; T15; T19; T20	11
2. Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement 2.1 Unnamed ideal-candidate profile	The creator describes the ideal president without naming a preferred candidate.	T01; T02; T03; T04; T05; T06; T07; T08; T09; T10; T11; T12; T13; T14; T15; T16; T17; T18; T19; T20	20
2. Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement 2.2 Explicit non-influence disclaimer	The creator explicitly says they are not telling viewers whom to vote for or are not trying to influence them.	T02; T08; T14	3
2. Indirect Candidate Framing and Non-Endorsement 2.3 Implied candidate fit	The wording suggests that a candidate matching the profile exists, without naming them.	T04; T07; T08; T14; T18	5
3. Dissatisfaction, Decline and National Renewal 3.1 Rejection of existing political rhetoric	Frustration with lies, empty promises, corruption, scandals or political performance.	T02; T03; T04; T08; T10; T12; T14; T15; T19; T20	10
3. Dissatisfaction, Decline and National Renewal 3.2 Social and institutional problems	Economic hardship, poor living conditions, education/health concerns and lack of trust.	T01; T09; T11; T20	4
3. Dissatisfaction, Decline and National Renewal 3.3 Change, progress and future	Calls for change, a better future, progress and rebuilding trust in Romania.	T01; T03; T05; T08; T09; T10; T12; T14; T15; T18; T19; T20	12
4. Mobilisation and Participatory TikTok Communication 4.1 Voting mobilisation and civic duty	Direct calls to vote or descriptions of voting as a right and responsibility.	T01; T02; T03; T08; T10; T12; T13; T14; T15; T19; T20	11
4. Mobilisation and Participatory TikTok Communication 4.2 Direct and collective audience address	The creator uses 'we' and 'you' to make the audience part of the discussion.	T01; T02; T03; T04; T05; T06; T07; T08; T09; T10; T11; T12; T13; T14; T15; T16; T17; T18; T19; T20	20
4. Mobilisation and Participatory TikTok Communication 4.3 Comment and discussion prompts	The creator asks viewers to share their own opinions or candidate criteria in the comments.	T09; T13; T14; T16; T17; T18	6
4. Mobilisation and Participatory TikTok Communication 4.4 Platform-native or informal framing	Politics is presented through informal TikTok styles such as humour, dialogue, lifestyle content or metaphors.	T04; T07; T08; T09; T11; T17; T20	7

Note. The final template was refined iteratively across the 20-video sample. A video could be coded to more than one sub-theme; counts therefore do not sum to 20.

Appendix D. Condensed Video-by-Video Coding Records

Note. These records retain only the fields needed to demonstrate application of the final template. Theme codes correspond to Table B1. Full transcripts and detailed working notes are retained separately.

Table C1. Template-analysis record: T01 - Bettyshor

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The presidential choice is presented as a response to social inequality and perceived state neglect, followed by a motivational call for citizens to become the change they want.
Candidate presentation	Grounded, egalitarian and socially aware; able to understand ordinary people's material conditions.
Tone and TikTok framing	Conversational, inclusive and morally evaluative, moving from concern and indignation to motivational language. Direct-to-audience address and an explicit voting call; the spoken content does not name a candidate.
Key English translation / quote	"Any president must understand the word equality, whether economic or spiritual." / "Be the change you want to see in this country, and be the one who goes out to vote."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 2.1, 3.2, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C2. Template-analysis record: T02 - Andreeabld

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	A denial of direct influence is followed by a highly specific set of criteria for choosing the president and a practical call to vote.
Candidate presentation	Serious, balanced, educated, patriotic and demonstrably effective.
Tone and TikTok framing	Conversational and emphatic, with repeated reassurance that the creator is not instructing viewers how to vote. Direct address, explicit non-influence disclaimer and practical voting instructions.
Key English translation / quote	"I do not want to influence you in any way." / "We need a president who has demonstrated his qualities through actions, not through words and false promises."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 2.2, 3.1, 4.1, 4.2

Table C3. Template-analysis record: T03 - Rebecca Toma

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The ideal president is defined through moral and professional qualities, while the audience is invited to replace political talk with visible change.
Candidate presentation	Honest, empathetic, competent across fields, correct and capable of turning promises into reality.
Tone and TikTok framing	Friendly, concise and motivational. Direct second-person address and explicit call to vote.
Key English translation / quote	"Integrity and honesty... [the president] must be empathetic to people's problems and competent in several fields." / "If you are tired of words and want to see changes, let us change Romania's future together."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.4, 2.1, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C4. Template-analysis record: T04 - Cristina Horez

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Political choice is translated into a familiar dating-app metaphor, while a specific ideal-candidate profile is constructed.
Candidate presentation	Experienced, accomplished, serious, scandal-free, balanced and patriotic.
Tone and TikTok framing	Humorous, colloquial and highly platform-native. Dialogue format and 'swipe right' metaphor make electoral evaluation resemble everyday TikTok entertainment.
Key English translation / quote	"If you talk a lot and your CV is empty, next!" / "Someone who has actually done something for Romania... balanced, patriotic."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 2.3, 3.1, 4.2, 4.4

Table C5. Template-analysis record: T05 - Braia Robert

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Voters are encouraged to judge candidates through competence, clean reputation and demonstrable achievements rather than treating all candidates as equally prepared.
Candidate presentation	Honest, corruption-free, experienced, accomplished, internationally capable and competent.
Tone and TikTok framing	Measured and criteria-based. Direct explanatory monologue; collective language about the country people want to live in.
Key English translation / quote	"We want an honest president who has not been involved in corruption scandals." / "We want to live in a country we can be proud of."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 3.3, 4.2

Table C6. Template-analysis record: T06 - Bianca Mitroi

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The presidency is framed as values-based leadership requiring both moral concern and practical competence across major policy areas.
Candidate presentation	Sincere, people-centred, nationally responsible, competent and visionary.
Tone and TikTok framing	Serious, explanatory and inclusive. Direct address, framed as a personal view rather than a named endorsement.
Key English translation / quote	"A president is not only a person who represents us on paper, but someone who supports our values, inspires us and defends our interests."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 4.2

Table C7. Template-analysis record: T07 - Sicutv

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The ideal president is constructed through a mix of competence, traditional personal values, national attachment and ordinary-person identification.
Candidate presentation	Honest, educated, family-oriented, patriotic, relatable and prepared with a long-term project.
Tone and TikTok framing	Informal, conversational and lightly humorous. Direct audience question and personalised profile-building.
Key English translation / quote	"[He should] care about Romania, love Romania, love Romanians, and be one of us."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 2.3, 4.2, 4.4

Table C8. Template-analysis record: T08 - Adriana Ciriblan

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	A disclaimer of influence is followed by a contrast between disappointing politics and a deserving, patriotic, clean candidate.
Candidate presentation	Proven, serious, patriotic, family-oriented, respectable, corruption-free and dependable.
Tone and TikTok framing	Conversational, frustrated and emphatic, with repeated protection of the creator's neutrality. Direct disclaimer, audience questions and mobilisation language.
Key English translation / quote	"I am not here to... influence your opinion in the vote." / "We want a serious president, a patriotic president, with a family, with respect."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2, 4.4

Table C9. Template-analysis record: T09 - Daiana Jrc

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Everyday dissatisfaction is connected to the presidential election as an opportunity for change, then reduced to a simple moral leadership profile.
Candidate presentation	Correct, honest and capable of leadership.
Tone and TikTok framing	Accessible, direct and concise. Broad occupational examples and explicit invitation to comment.
Key English translation / quote	"Whatever field you work in, you certainly have many things you are unhappy with. The presidential election is coming, so now is a major chance for all of us to make a change."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 2.1, 3.2, 3.3, 4.2, 4.3, 4.4

Table C10. Template-analysis record: T10 - Beatrice Nth

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The voter should choose a prepared, trustworthy and principled leader on the basis of demonstrated capacity rather than rhetoric.
Candidate presentation	Serious, honest, balanced, institutionally knowledgeable, responsible and prepared.
Tone and TikTok framing	Concise, directive and criteria-based. Collective appeal to make a responsible choice; no candidate named.
Key English translation / quote	"We need a serious, honest and balanced leader." / "Someone prepared and trustworthy, based on facts and not just words."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.4, 2.1, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C11. Template-analysis record: T11 - Bunica Lucretia

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Legitimate leadership is tied to lived experience, honest work, institutional competence, public service and moral/religious character.
Candidate presentation	Experienced, self-made, honest, institutionally knowledgeable, socially responsible, serious, correct and religiously grounded.
Tone and TikTok framing	Intergenerational, conversational and familiar. Family/grandmother dialogue gives political criteria an everyday, relatable form.
Key English translation / quote	"A person who started from the bottom and rose through his work, through honest work." / "We need a president who has demonstrated his qualities through actions, not words."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 3.2, 4.2, 4.4

Table C12. Template-analysis record: T12 - DragaViitoareMama

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The presidency is framed as a role requiring both professional credibility and morally grounded national commitment.
Candidate presentation	Qualified, institutionally competent, patriotic, honest, corruption-resistant, family-oriented and balanced.
Tone and TikTok framing	Measured, advisory and serious. Direct explanatory monologue asking the audience to think carefully about the choice.
Key English translation / quote	"Patriotism and honesty are essential." / "We need a leader with a solid career, with real studies, someone who knows very well how state institutions work."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C13. Template-analysis record: T13 - Denisa Asmr

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	The audience is encouraged to evaluate candidates according to a standardised set of moral and competence criteria.
Candidate presentation	Honest, patriotic, educated, family-oriented, capable, serious, correct and prepared.
Tone and TikTok framing	Straightforward, list-based and participatory. Question-and-comment call encourages viewers to reproduce the ideal-candidate discussion.
Key English translation / quote	"[The president] should be honest, patriotic, well educated, family-oriented, a good leader, serious and correct."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 4.1, 4.2, 4.3

Table C14. Template-analysis record: T14 - Beatrice Adriana

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Voter autonomy is verbally protected while the creator supplies a detailed profile of the desirable president and links voting to national change.
Candidate presentation	Honest, corruption-free, accomplished, serious, nationally oriented, balanced and proven through action.
Tone and TikTok framing	Careful, explanatory and explicitly non-directive at the start, becoming more motivational at the end. Explicit disclaimer, direct questions to viewers and a call to vote.
Key English translation / quote	"I am not here... to influence your opinion in the vote." / "Not just a good speaker, but a person who has demonstrated through actions that they can lead the country."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 2.2, 2.3, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2, 4.3

Table C15. Template-analysis record: T15 - Madalina

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	A morally disciplined and patriotic leader with demonstrated achievements is presented as the route away from empty rhetoric and towards national renewal.
Candidate presentation	Balanced, serious, patriotic, clean, honest, disciplined, principled and proven.
Tone and TikTok framing	Collective, emphatic and repetitive. Strong inclusive 'we' framing and explicit voting call.
Key English translation / quote	"We need a president who has demonstrated his qualities through actions and not through words." / "We are tired of words; we want actions."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 1.4, 2.1, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C16. Template-analysis record: T16 - Adina Miuleasa

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Candidate evaluation is narrowed to competence and exemplary leadership rather than party or named-candidate discussion.
Candidate presentation	Capable, institutionally knowledgeable, educated and exemplary.
Tone and TikTok framing	Reflective and explanatory. Personal-opinion framing and explicit viewer question.
Key English translation / quote	"A good leader must have the necessary abilities; they must be capable of leading us." / "They must know how the institutions of this country work."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 2.1, 4.2, 4.3

Table C17. Template-analysis record: T17 - Nitu Denis

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Private-sector management and conventional personal responsibility are translated into presidential competence.
Candidate presentation	Fair, educated, family-oriented and entrepreneurial/managerial.
Tone and TikTok framing	Informal and speculative. Personal-profile framing and a direct comment invitation.
Key English translation / quote	"If you know how to manage a company, I think you can also manage a country."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 2.1, 4.2, 4.3, 4.4

Table C18. Template-analysis record: T18 - Bella Caramela

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Moral character, education and patriotism are bundled into a profile that the audience is invited to match to a candidate.
Candidate presentation	Honest, educated, empathetic and patriotic, placing the country first.
Tone and TikTok framing	Friendly, list-based and participatory. Explicit collective search for a matching candidate and comment prompt.
Key English translation / quote	"The future president of Romania should be patriotic and put the country first." / "I want us to find together a candidate who has all these qualities."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.3, 2.1, 2.3, 3.3, 4.2, 4.3

Table C19. Template-analysis record: T19 - Roxana

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	A disciplined, authentic and action-oriented leader is positioned as part of national renewal and the return of Romanians abroad.
Candidate presentation	Balanced, honest, brave, disciplined, principled and demonstrably effective.
Tone and TikTok framing	Collective, repetitive and emphatic. Strong collective phrasing and short voting CTA.
Key English translation / quote	"We need a president who has demonstrated his qualities through actions and not through words." / "We want actions, not words."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.4, 2.1, 3.1, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2

Table C20. Template-analysis record: T20 - Madalina19

Analytical field	Coded content
Message / narrative	Personal frustration about youth opportunities becomes a civic argument for voting and choosing an educated, trustworthy leader who can support national renewal.
Candidate presentation	Good, honest, trustworthy, educated, cultured, serious, professionally grounded and reliable.
Tone and TikTok framing	Personal, earnest and reflective. Personal example, direct appeal and civic-duty framing.
Key English translation / quote	"Voting is very important because our ancestors fought so that we could have this right." / "They should be an educated, cultured and well-read person."
Final sub-theme codes	1.1, 1.2, 1.4, 2.1, 3.1, 3.2, 3.3, 4.1, 4.2, 4.4

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SHEFFIELD HALLAM UNIVERSITY / MA DIGITAL MEDIA MANAGEMENT / 2026

MARKETING AS A MODERN COUP D'ÉTAT

Developing a Strategic Framework for Analysing Electoral Influence on TikTok

20 TikTok videos. One repeated presidential profile. No preferred candidate named.

Alexandru-Andrei Iordache • Supervisor: Geir Laingen

RESEARCH AIM

To develop a strategic framework for analysing how marketing and platform-native communication techniques may contribute to electoral influence on TikTok, using influencer content from Romania's 2024 presidential election as the case study.

CASE STUDY

Romania's 2024 presidential election

During Romania's 2024 presidential election, influencers received coordinated instructions to describe their ideal president on TikTok. Although they named no candidate, the repeated qualities closely matched the messaging of presidential candidate Călin Georgescu. This study analyses 20 of these videos to examine how coordinated political communication was adapted into apparently personal creator content.

METHOD

20 VIDEOS, ONE PER CREATOR

Template Analysis (iterative theme coding)
Spoken/transcribed content coded
Videos posted 1 Sep - 24 Nov 2024
Patterns compared across all 20 videos

HOW TO READ THE COUNTS

Counts describe this 20-video sample, not the whole campaign. Coding mainly examined spoken/transcribed content, and some deleted posts were recovered from archival material. No audience or voting effects were measured.

PROPOSED STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

HOW THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS MAY WORK



Comments can create visibility signals; voluntary repetition may spread the message beyond the original coordinated campaign.

KEY FINDINGS • 20-VIDEO SAMPLE

IDEAL-PRESIDENT CRITERIA



INDIRECT FRAMING

20/20 videos described the ideal president but named no preferred candidate

3/20 explicitly denied trying to influence viewers, then still supplied detailed criteria.
5/20 implied that a matching candidate could be found.

MOBILISATION

20/20 direct / collective address
11/20 voting / civic duty
6/20 comment prompts
7/20 informal TikTok framing

"We are tired of words; we want actions."

T15, translated

CORE INTERPRETATION

Although creators did not name or directly endorse a candidate, their repeated ideal-president criteria closely aligned with one campaign, creating an indirect endorsement presented through familiar, personal TikTok content.

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